Talking With Dad About the House

What he wants, whose name is on it, and what to leave undecided.

Everyone in the family has a view about Dad's house, and Dad has his own. It's his house, and it may be that nobody has asked him yet what he wants for it.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: hear what Dad wants, and put what everyone knows about the house on one page. It isn't for deciding anything.

Who should be there

Dad, first. It's his home, and the conversation is with him, not about him. Then whoever he'd like there: his spouse if he's married, his children, anyone who lives in the house or helps look after it. Someone who can't come can send their questions ahead.

Pick one person to take notes. It shouldn't be the person leading the conversation.

How to open

Choose an ordinary day, with nothing else going on. Start with a question, not a proposal, and say plainly that nothing is being decided.

- “Dad, nothing's wrong and nothing has to change. We've realized none of us knows what you'd want for the house, and we'd like to hear it from you.”
- “Each of us knows a different bit about the house. We'd like to put it on one page, and we want your version first.”
- Say what the conversation is for: hearing what he wants and getting the facts in one place. Say what it isn't for: changing the deed, or deciding who gets what.

Questions to ask

Ask Dad

1. What would you like for the house in the years ahead?

2. Whose name is on the deed, as far as you remember, and where is it kept?

3. Is there anything you've already arranged or signed about the house that you'd like us to know?

4. Who would you want with you when the family talks to a professional about it?

Ask each other

1. What do you know about the house, and where did you learn it: from a paper, or from something someone said?

2. Who lives in the house now, and who helps look after it?

3. What changes has anyone suggested, and who suggested them?

4. What don't any of us know yet, and what would we want to ask a professional?

How to write down what was said

Keep Dad's own words separate from what the family knows or has heard. Where two people remember something differently, write both and don't settle it. Whose name is on the deed is something to look up on the deed itself, not to settle from memory; the rest are questions for a professional.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	FROM A PAPER OR FROM MEMORY	REMEMBERED DIFFERENTLY BY
“I'd like to stay here as long as I can. Past that, I haven't thought about it.”	Dad	His own words	
The deed is in Dad's name only.	Karen	Memory; she hasn't seen the deed	David thinks a second name was added years ago

What not to decide yet

These stay open. Questions about the deed, a transfer or a trust go to an elder law attorney who knows Dad's state, and your notes from this conversation are what you'd bring.

- Whether to change the deed or add anyone's name to it.
- Whether to give or transfer the house to anyone.
- Whether a trust, or anything else someone has suggested, is right for Dad.
- Who was right about what the deed says.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the notes and send them to everyone, Dad included.
- Who will find the deed with Dad and note the names on it and its date.
- Who will take each open question to your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney.
- When you'll talk again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, say what should happen with the house, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets Dad's wishes and the family's facts onto one page, with the differences left on it. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has heard what Dad wants for the house and written it down, with nothing decided. The planning interview takes it from there: it asks about your family's situation as a whole and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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